

Run an Adaptive Fishing Day

Field loop 2 of 3

Observe, test, record, move

WEATHER IS THE FIRST PATTERN

Do not launch when thunderstorms are possible. At thunder or threatening weather, stop fishing and head to port or safe shelter early. An open boat is not safe shelter. Wear a fitted life jacket; cold water removes self-rescue ability quickly.

The loop



Observe	Wind lane, light, surface temperature, clarity, cover, bottom change, bait, marks, follows, bites.
Predict	Name a location, depth band, presentation, and stop time.
Test	Hold all but one variable steady. Count casts or minutes.
Record	Note evidence, including misses and empty water. Decide: refine, switch, or stop.

A compact pattern ladder

1. **Visible shallow cover.** Quiet approach; compact bait; parallel the edge before crossing it.
2. **First break outside cover.** Use a presentation that maintains depth and transmits bottom.
3. **Hard/soft or depth transition.** Search along it; slow only after contact, marks, or a bite.
4. **Suspended evidence.** Match the marked depth; do not fish beneath fish merely because bottom is easy to see.

The one-change rule

If location is unknown, search. If fish are seen but do not respond, change presentation. If they bite but do not stay pinned, change hook, size, or handling. Never change location, depth, speed, and bait together: success then teaches nothing.

Release is decided before the cast

- Use tackle strong enough to land the fish promptly.
- Prefer tackle that reduces deep hooking.
- Ready net, pliers, measure, and camera first.
- Wet hands; support the fish; do not squeeze.
- Minimize handling and air exposure.
- Return it when it can hold balance.

Trip log

Lake: _____
Date/time: _____
Wind/light: _____
Water/clarity: _____
Evidence: _____
Next test: _____

Evidence. Safety: Wisconsin DNR Boating Safety and Life Jackets; NOAA/NWS inland boating and thunderstorm guidance. Fish care: Wisconsin DNR catch-and-release guidelines. Checked 2026-07-26. Tactics are testable editorial hypotheses, not survey findings.

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